MODULE 11
Founder Mental Health & Well-Being
Sustainable Success Starts With You

ASSIGNMENT: Create your personal well-being protocol

A joint initiative by

CHECK-IN

How are you really doing?

1. Energy - Rate 1-10: How's your energy this week?
2. Stress - What's your biggest stressor right now?
3. Joy - What brought you joy recently?

This is a safe space - be honest with yourself and your team

RECAP: From Module 10

1. You killed the features that didn't pass the filter
2. You measured PMF honestly — survey plus retention
3. Today: the most important asset — YOU

72% of founders say building affected their mental health (Startup Snapshot 2023)

Today

Check-in — how are you REALLY? (10')

The founder's reality — what the data says (10')

IDEA 1 · Manage energy, not time (15')

IDEA 2 · Resilience is trainable (10')

IDEA 3 · Protect your hours (10')

PART II · What failure feels like — the blik story (15')

Case · Founder wellbeing vignettes (20')

Workshop · The Energy Audit + revenue pulse (105')

Wrap-up · protocol + pitch draft v1 + €2,000 (5')

The Founder's Reality

72%

say building their startup affected their mental health (Startup Snapshot 2023, industry survey)

2x

lifetime depression: 30% of founders vs ~15% comparison group (Freeman et al. 2015)

49%

reported at least one lifetime mental-health condition (Freeman et al. 2015, n=242 vs 93 matched)

The Founder's Dilemma

Unlimited work, limited time and energy

High uncertainty = chronic stress activation

Identity fusion with the company

Social isolation from 'normal' life

Your startup can only be as healthy as you are.

IDEA 1: Manage energy, not time

Elite performers oscillate: sprint, then recover — on purpose.

Four dimensions: body, emotions, mind, purpose. The lowest one is your bottleneck.

The Science of Full Engagement

Research by Loehr & Schwartz (2003) on elite performers:

Core Finding: Elite performers manage ENERGY, not just time.

They oscillate between stress and recovery — like athletes training:

Sprint, then recover | Push, then restore | Intense focus, then deliberate rest

Energy is renewable. Time is not.

The question isn't 'How do I get more hours?'

It's 'How do I bring more energy to my hours?'

The Four Dimensions of Energy

1. PHYSICAL — The Foundation

   Sleep, nutrition, exercise, recovery

   Without it, nothing else works

2. EMOTIONAL — The Quality

   Self-confidence, empathy, patience

   Negative emotions drain exponentially

3. MENTAL — The Focus

   Concentration, creativity, time management

   Every decision depletes mental energy

4. SPIRITUAL — The Why

   Purpose, values, commitment

   Connects daily tasks to larger meaning

Physical Energy: The Foundation

SLEEP — The Non-Negotiable Multiplier

7-9 hours required, 6 hours = legally drunk impairment, Sleep debt cannot be caught up

EXERCISE — The Catalyst

20-30 min/day minimum: walking counts, Produces BDNF (brain fertilizer), Morning exercise improves decisions all day

NUTRITION — The Fuel

Stable blood sugar = stable mood and focus

Even mild dehydration measurably impairs attention and mood

Emotional Energy: Quality Matters

Negative emotions drain energy exponentially.

Positive emotions expand capacity.

THE STRESS RESPONSE:

- Acute stress: Performance enhancing (short-term)
- Chronic stress: Depleting and damaging (kills creativity, health)

REGULATION STRATEGIES:

- Name emotions to reduce amygdala activation
- Deep breathing: 4-7-8 technique (activates parasympathetic)
- Physical movement: Walk it off, literally

RELATIONSHIPS MATTER:

- Founders with strong support systems show markedly higher resilience

Mental Energy: Focus & Flow

Mental energy is finite. Every decision depletes it.

Willpower must be protected, not tested.

THE ATTENTION ECONOMY:

- Context switching costs ~23 minutes to recover (Mark, UC Irvine)
- Deep work requires 90-120 minute blocks
- Multitasking is rapid switching (it's a myth)

CAL NEWPORT'S DEEP WORK RULES:

- Work deeply: Schedule uninterrupted blocks
- Embrace boredom: Don't reach for phone every pause
- Quit social media: Or be ruthless about usage
- Drain the shallows: Batch email, Slack, admin tasks

Decision Fatigue: Make important decisions in the morning.

Spiritual Energy: The Why

Purpose provides fuel when motivation fades.

CONNECTING TO MEANING:

- Why did you start this company?
- Who are you serving?
- What change do you want to see in the world?

VALUES AS A COMPASS:

- Clear values speed up decisions
- Value conflicts drain energy (listen to the discomfort)
- Alignment between actions and values = sustainable energy

'He who has a why can bear almost any how.' — Nietzsche

When things get hard, purpose is your anchor.

IDEA 2: Resilience is trainable

Failure is data, not identity. Watch your burnout gauges early.

Build the support network BEFORE you need it.

Building Resilience

Resilience is NOT avoiding stress.

It's the capacity to recover quickly and grow from adversity.

It can be trained like a muscle.

COGNITIVE REFRAMING (Dweck, 2006):

- Failure = data, not identity
- Problems = puzzles to solve
- 'What can I learn?' not 'Why me?'
- Growth mindset measurably increases persistence (Dweck, 2006)

PRACTICAL PRACTICES:

- Gratitude journaling: 3 things daily
- Post-failure analysis: What worked? What to try next?
- Deliberate reflection: Don't just keep moving, pause and learn

Burnout Warning Signs

Burnout isn't a badge of honor. It's a failure to recover.

PHYSICAL SIGNS:

- Constant fatigue despite sleep
- Frequent illness (immune system weakened)
- Changes in appetite or sleep patterns

EMOTIONAL SIGNS:

- Cynicism about your work or mission
- Feeling detached from the outcome
- Irritability with team, customers, everyone

COGNITIVE SIGNS:

- Difficulty concentrating
- Poor decision-making
- Loss of creativity

Building Your Support Network

Entrepreneurship is lonely. You don't have to do it alone.

YOUR SUPPORT NETWORK:

1. CO-FOUNDER / PARTNER: Someone who shares the weight
2. MENTOR: Someone who's been there (use your TUM network!)
3. PEER FOUNDER GROUP: Others in the trenches — they understand
4. THERAPIST / COACH: Professional support for the psychological load
5. LIFE OUTSIDE WORK: Friends, family, hobbies — identity beyond startup

IDEA 3: Protect your hours

Eisenhower + 80/20: your best hours go to your hardest problems.

If you could only work two hours today — do that. Delegate or delete the rest.

The Time Management Challenge

Entrepreneurs wear many hats simultaneously:

CEO, salesperson, product manager, recruiter, customer support...

Unlike employees with defined roles, founders must

strategically allocate their most limited resource: TIME.

KEY STATISTICS:

- Time is the #1 self-reported founder challenge
- 50+ hours/week is the norm (often 60-80)
- A founder covers a dozen job functions at once

THE PARADOX: You can always make more money.

You can never make more time.

Time management IS energy management.

The Eisenhower Matrix

URGENT + IMPORTANT → DO FIRST

Crisis, deadlines, key customer issues | Handle immediately, minimize

NOT URGENT + IMPORTANT → SCHEDULE

Strategy, planning, relationships, learning | This is where growth happens

URGENT + NOT IMPORTANT → DELEGATE

Most emails, some calls, other people's priorities | Learn to say no

NOT URGENT + NOT IMPORTANT → ELIMINATE

Time wasters, busy work, social media scrolling | Be ruthless

'What is important is seldom urgent...' — Eisenhower

The 80/20 Rule (Pareto Principle)

20% of effort drives 80% of results.

Identify and double down on the vital few activities

that generate most of your impact.

APPLY 80/20 TO:

- Customers: Which 20% generate 80% of revenue?
- Features: Which 20% create 80% of value?
- Tasks: Which 20% move the needle most?
- Meetings: Which 20% are actually useful?

THE BRUTAL QUESTION:

If you could only work 2 hours today, what would you do?

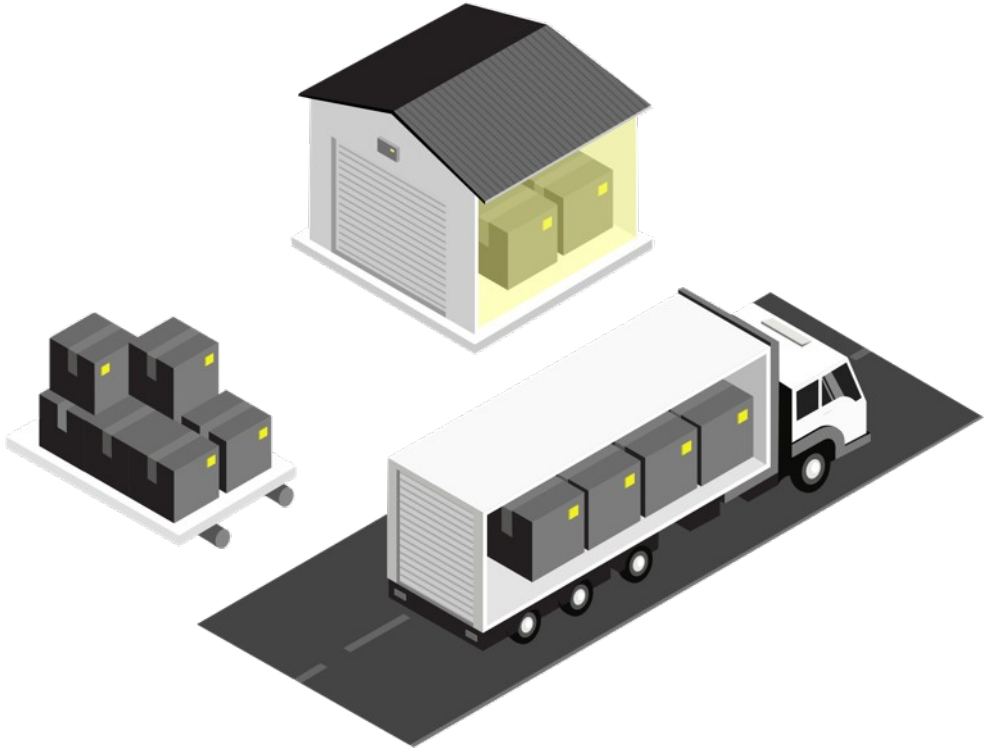
Do more of that. Eliminate or delegate the rest.

PART II: What failure feels like

blik — my own startup: funded, praised, and dead anyway.

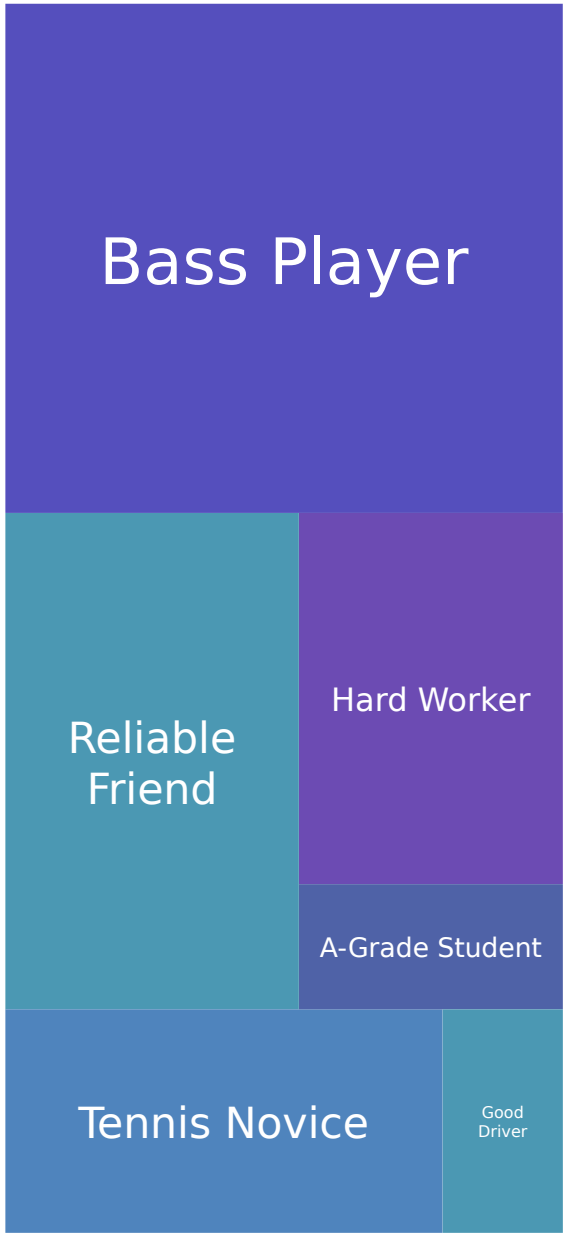
What identity fusion does to you, and why I stand here as the luckiest man alive.

blik



„One of the **most promising startups** of the year!“

When have we built some-thing our customers will love? The next big deal is **still** around the corner.


Bass Player
Reliable Friend
Hard Worker
A-Grade Student
Tennis Novice
Good Driver

You are not your work!

Questions founders actually ask (CDTM cohort)

'How do I know I have a great founder team?' — You'll know under load, not over coffee. That's why M01 made you test the partnership.

'Can I keep healthy habits?' — It's hard, and harder than a corporate job. A co-founder who keeps you in check beats any app.

'Should I follow a smaller vision so I don't burn out?' — No. A restaurant can burn you out exactly like Google can — you'll fill the hours either way. A big vision at least forces you to focus on what really matters.

'How do I build a culture of healthy habits?' — Up to ~20 people, what the founders DO is the culture. Gym at lunch, real food, passion projects: your team copies behavior, never memos — internally and externally.

The hard three

'How do I know I've failed?' — You'll notice too late; the next big thing always feels just around the corner. When the energy to execute new ideas is gone — that is a fair point to let it be.

'Ego or no ego?' — No ego. You can stay deeply passionate without ego. And know when to step down or sideways to make the cake bigger.

'Work on weaknesses or strengths?' — Strengths. Well documented scientifically. Hire and partner for the gaps instead — remember the homophily alarm from Module 1.



- You don‘t get it until you have been there
- It‘s a learning journey nobody regrets
- It‘s always tough with your co-founders
- In the end, it was too long
- There is always the next big thing around the corner
- „Everything is great“ is a lie



- It get‘s you when you least expect it
- Take more time for yourself than you anticipate
- Liquidation takes longer than you think
- Never leave with a grudge
- Don‘t jump into the next thing

jejange.”

“It always turned out fine.”

—— §3 Rheinisches Grundgesetz

Personal Energy Audit

Rate yourself honestly (1-10):

PHYSICAL (1-10): Sleep quality? Exercise frequency? Energy levels throughout day?

Your score: ___

EMOTIONAL (1-10): Stress levels? Quality relationships? Emotional regulation?

Your score: ___

MENTAL (1-10): Focus duration? Decision quality? Creative capacity?

Your score: ___

SPIRITUAL (1-10): Sense of purpose? Alignment with values? Motivation levels?

Your score: ___

Your lowest score is your biggest constraint.

Key Takeaways

1. MANAGE ENERGY, NOT JUST TIME: Your capacity fluctuates. Schedule work to match energy rhythms.

2. OSCILLATE: STRESS THEN RECOVERY: Elite performance requires rhythmic renewal. Sprints, not marathons.

3. PROTECT YOUR PHYSICAL FOUNDATION: Sleep, exercise, nutrition are non-negotiable.

4. PRIORITIZE RUTHLESSLY: Use Eisenhower Matrix + 80/20. Not all tasks are equal.

5. BUILD YOUR SUPPORT NETWORK: You can't do this alone. Ask for help.

→ **Next week: Demo Day prep — pitch draft v1 becomes the real thing, and the company decides to outlive the course.**

WORKSHOP: The Energy Audit (90 min)

Agenda lives in M11_Workshop_Energy-Audit.md — one source of truth.

Must produce: your personal well-being protocol + a well-being buddy from this class.

Plus: the 15-minute revenue/pipeline pulse — the sprint to €2,000 does not pause this week.

A protocol with more than 5 items is a wish list. You won't do 6.

The S.T.O.P. Method

When stress hits, use this 60-second reset:

S - STOP: Pause whatever you're doing

T - TAKE: Take 3 deep breaths

O - OBSERVE: Notice thoughts and feelings

P - PROCEED: Continue with awareness

REFLECTION

Homework (M11_Homework.md): protocol daily · co-founder check-in · pitch draft v1 · revenue toward €2,000 pass / €5,000 stretch

Resources: TUM Psychological Counseling | Startup Mental Health Hotline

Thank You!

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APPENDIX — original slides (3 restored as images)

These pages from the pre-rework deck are not in the current flow. Source snapshot: Instructor/original-decks/M11_Lecture_ORIGINAL.pdf.

Mark each: KEEP (design pass rebuilds it properly, editable) or KILL. Nothing gets deleted without your call.

Time Blocking: Protect Your Best Hours

EXAMPLE: FOUNDER'S DAY

8:00 AM — Deep Work: Product Development

10:00 AM — Customer Interviews

11:00 AM — Team Sync (max 30 min)

12:00 PM — Lunch (not at desk)

1:00 PM — Admin Batch (email, Slack, calls)

2:00 PM — Deep Work: Strategy/Planning

4:00 PM — Meetings (if absolutely necessary)

5:00 PM — Reflection & Tomorrow's Planning

RULES FOR TIME BLOCKING:

- Your best hours go to your hardest problems
- Batch similar tasks together
- Build in buffer time (things take longer)
- Protect blocks like you protect customer meetings

Lessons from Successful Founders

BRIAN CHESKY (Airbnb):

During COVID, lost 80% of business in 8 weeks.

Response: Focused on what he could control, made hard decisions fast.

'The company nearly died. But crisis creates clarity.'

EV WILLIAMS (Twitter, Medium):

Serial entrepreneur who practices daily meditation.

Starts each day with 30 min of silence before any devices.

'The biggest competitive advantage is a clear mind.'

REID HOFFMAN (LinkedIn):

'Entrepreneurship is jumping off a cliff and assembling a plane on the way down.'

Emphasizes: sustainable speed over unsustainable sprints.

Thank You!

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